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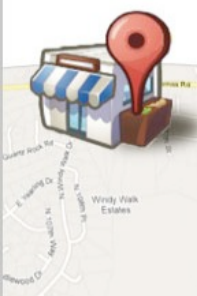
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YOUR STRATEGY - STARTING OUT

Advertisers set sights on Generation Y

July 22, 2007 | By Carolyn Bigda, Chicago Tribune

Today's twentysomethings are fast becoming the focus of advertisers. Baby boomers are retiring. And in their stead, Generation Y, those born from 1981 to 1995, promises to have just as much purchasing power.

Generation Y is the largest group since the baby boomers, who were born in 1946 to 1964. Within less than a decade, Gen Yers are expected by some to be the most influential consumers in the U.S. economy.

That fact is not lost on retailers.

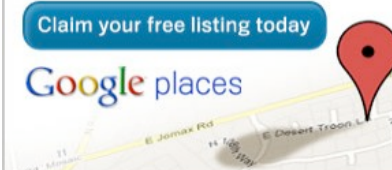
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A steady stream of industry advice tells how to drive a "brand into the brains" of teenagers and twentysomethings, or how to "get younger." Companies are restructuring their business to cater to what are considered Gen Y interests, such as social responsibility.

"Some of my clients have changed their marketing message to show, for example, that they care about the environment," said Anand Chhatpar, chief executive of BrainReactions, which helps companies create new products and ad campaigns geared toward Generation Y.

While more environmentally conscious companies may be good for the planet, you still want to make sure you stay in control of your spending. Here are some tips:

Recognize when you are being marketed to. With advertising seemingly everywhere these days, experts say mass media have less influence on Gen Yers than previous generations.

"They trust their peers a lot more than traditional advertising," Chhatpar said.

So more companies are turning to so-called viral marketing, in which a message is spread by word-of-mouth.

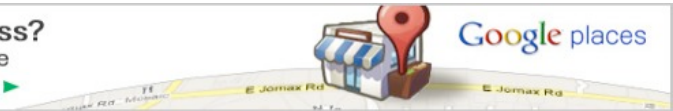
Marketing in the form of interactive games or giveaways is also becoming increasingly common. Take, for example, Burger King's campaign at www.subservientchicken.com, a video in which a human-size chicken does almost any command you type.

Stay skeptical. Seeing a chicken dance on your computer screen can be entertaining, but keep in mind that no matter how creative the marketing, a business is still trying to sell you something.

And peer reviews cut both ways: Although the Internet has made it possible for consumers to share advice on products and services, there is often no way to check who is doing the writing.

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